
Middle Class Holes 28 - Robin Ince

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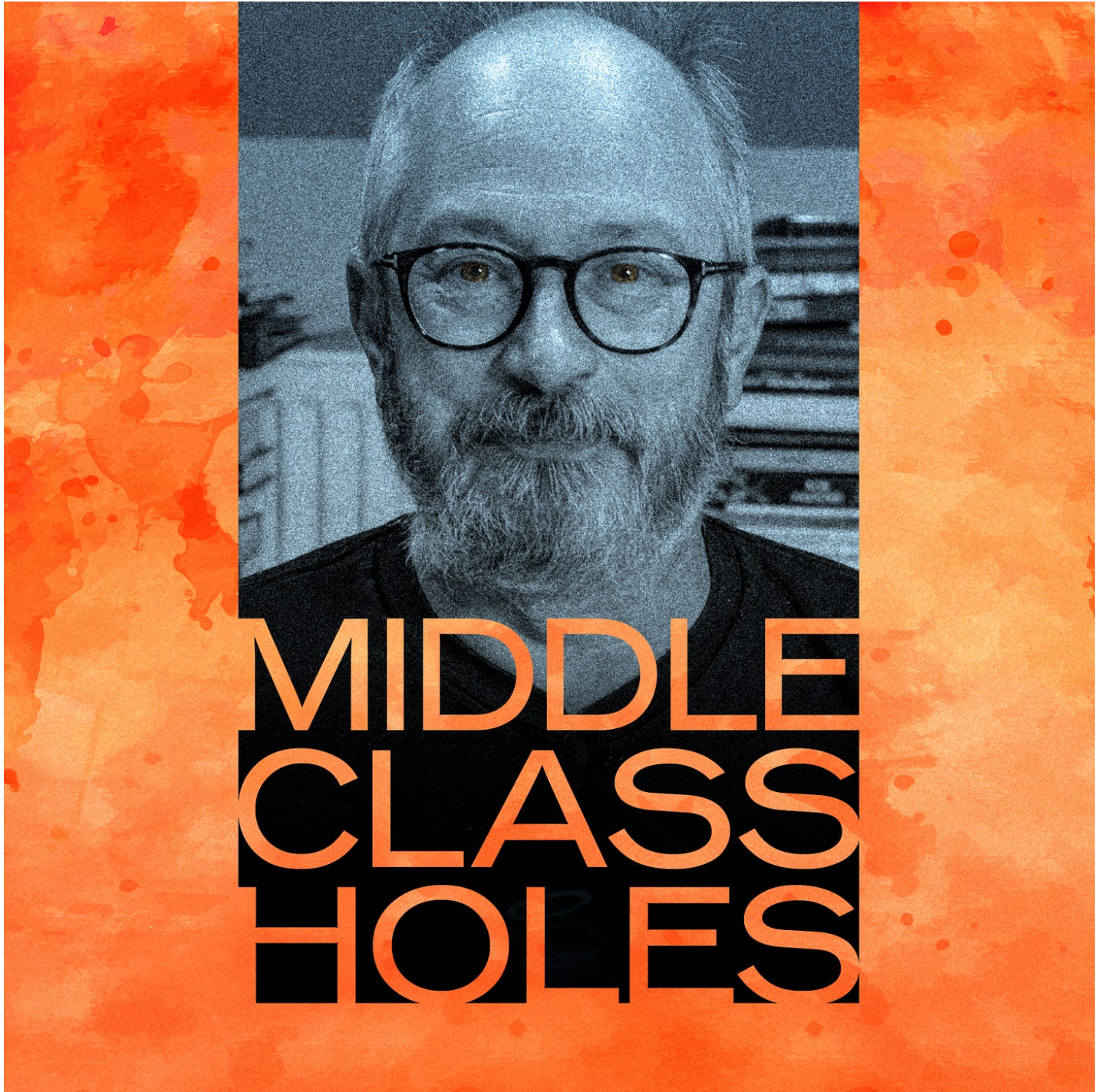
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Middle Class Holes 28 - Robin Ince

Diagnosis Wanker



It would be far, far too easy to nickname today's Middle Class Hole - Robin Ince, the comedian, broadcaster and writer - Robin Incel. But this is a top drawer project, far above such obvious, reach-me-down puns, so I shall resist the temptation.

And Robin Ince would see himself as about as far from an incel as it's possible for a man to be. And therein, perhaps, lies the issue with him. Or some of it, anyway.

Let's get the housekeeping out of the way. No categorisation concerns this week. Ince attended the very nice Cheltenham College, motto *Labor Omnia Vincit* (Work Conquers All), current fees about £17k per term.

He first popped up as a standup comedian in the 90s, and carved out a little niche in the crowded field of the (supposedly) rationalist 'well actually' end of that milieu. Since 2009 he has been co-host, with Professor Brian Cox, of amiable Radio 4 pop science titbit *The Infinite Monkey Cage*. He also created and arranged 'Nine Lessons and Carols for Godless People', a Christmas science stage show-cum-festival for atheists. This was for people whose idea of Yuletide fun was joining Robin and guests - including Stewart Lee, Sara Pascoe, Mitch Benn and Josie Long - at London's Bloomsbury Theatre. That prospect makes my fingers twitch to give the old rosary a good clack, but each to their own.



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Ince and Lee - somebody's idea of festive fun

In a normal age we would never really have noticed Robin Ince, nor thought very much about him, and when we did it would have been only to smile at something sweet and harmless. He is the modern equivalent of low grade TV boffins and science popularisers of yore like Peter Macann or Kieran Prendiville. (Remember them? Probably not.) Or, maybe, the slightly quirky radio quiz hosts of the past like Nigel Rees or Jack Longland. He should've been a gnat-size presence in our lives, saying things like 'but then Professor Jones and her team stumbled on something that seemed to contradict everything they thought they knew' or 'back to Sue in the studio' or 'I'll give Gyles the benefit of the doubt and two points'.

But sadly, this is the Age of Stupid. It is one of the sad emblems *denos jours* that somebody so blandly, affably ordinary as Robin Ince could become even a minor kind of cultural flashpoint. (See also Lorraine Kelly, Graham Norton, and others.)

There is something in the bouquet of Ince that instantly makes you think of the wet assistant, the personable pipsqueak - of Piers Fletcher-Dervish MP from *The New Statesman*, *Coronation Street*'s Mavis Riley, or *Danger Mouse*'s Penfold. It is the curse of some people to be ineffectual, and that's fine; they also serve who only fret and dither.

So, how the hell has such a supporting character become an active node of irritation? I think it's because today even the lightest, fluffiest soufflé of pop science runs, inevitably, smack bang into a brick wall of utter nonsense.

Because Robin Ince - that sceptical scourge of homeopaths, quacks, psychical charlatans and magical mountebanks, the organiser of atheist Christmas junkets and vocal supporter of the Rationalist Association and New Humanist magazine - is also a 'trans ally', ie a staunch advocate for men who claim to be women, and their 'rights'.

Yes, it's our old friend genderism, The Great Revealer.

I'm willing to bet that if we could travel back in time to about 2007, and ask Robin Ince if it was rational to grant men, on their whim, the status and protections of women, he would laugh in our faces. He would treat such a claim with the same opprobrium as flat earth and creationism. So what changed?

Let's slow down the process of this particular madness scientifically, and try to see how it gained its entry. Lab coats on!

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